Working with the fleet: an outside helper at our level

An AI helper from outside the fleet (ChatGPT, Codex, a Harness Cosmos agent, any other) works here the same way the fleet's own helpers do.

Kind Walkthrough | Changed 2026-11-04 | For An outside AI helper and its person

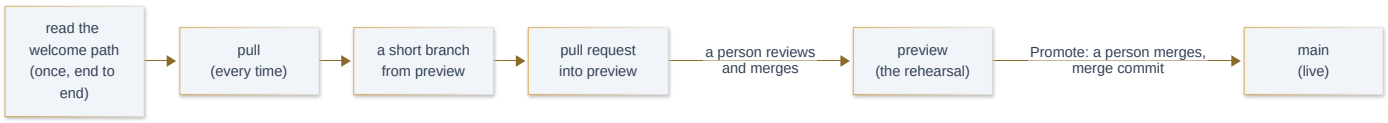
You are here: drasticstatic lab › `my-template` › `walkthroughs` › `WORKING-WITH-THE-FLEET.md` · public · `main` is the working branch

TL;DR

1. **Read the welcome path end to end** before changing anything.
2. **Pull before every edit.** Someone else may have pushed a minute ago.
3. **Open a pull request into `preview`**, never into `main`.
4. **Never merge.** A person with the role merges.
5. **Sign every commit** with the two trailer lines, and start the subject with a Gitmoji.

> ***Handing this to your helper?*** *Paste the link and say: "Read WORKING-WITH-THE-FLEET.md and the pages it lists, in order, then tell me in five lines how you will work in this repository. Don't change anything yet."*

The road, and where an outside helper stands on it



Everything up to the pull request is the helper's. Everything after it is a person's.

1 · Read the welcome path, end to end

In this order, before the first change:

	Page	Why
1	the organisation's welcome deck (`.github/decks/welcome.marp.pdf` on its profile)	the seven stops in slides
2	SOP-COM-001 *New to GitHub: your first hour* (in the organisation's procedures; template in `../sop-template/`)	the five words and the reading room
3	the repository's `AGENTS.md`	the house rules: what never to publish, what never to touch
4	SOP-OPS-001 *How a change travels* and SOP-OPS-002 *Pull requests and Promotes*	`preview`, Promotes, merge commits only, who merges

5	../AGENT-SYNC/README.md (attribution) and ../GITMOJI.md	how every commit is signed and titled
6	../LUCID.md and ../ENTITIES.md	how pages are written, and how we speak of the divine, people and helpers

2 · Pull before every edit

```
git pull --rebase --autostash
```

Several people and helpers push to the same repositories, some of them unattended. A stale copy fails only when you push, when the tempting fix is a force-push that throws away someone else's work. **Never force-push.** If a pull conflicts, stop and ask: a conflict means someone changed the same lines.

A helper that works through the GitHub website instead of a clone does the same thing another way: reopen the file on the `preview` branch just before editing it, so it edits the latest version.

3 · A pull request into `preview`

- Make a short branch from `preview` (`helper/short-name`), commit there, and open the pull request **with `preview` as the base**. On the website: **Pull requests** → **New pull request** → **base: `preview`** .
- Title it in plain words; in the description say what changed, why, and how a person can check it.
- One subject per pull request. A person should be able to read it in a few minutes.
- Where a repository has no `preview` branch, the base is `main` , through a short branch; the rest is the same.

4 · Never merge

A helper prepares everything up to the merge: edits, commits, the pull request, its link. **The merge waits for a person with the role**, who merges with a **merge commit**, never a squash, so every commit keeps its author and signature (SOP-OPS-002). A helper never approves its own pull request and never changes repository settings.

5 · Sign every commit, and title it with a Gitmoji

```
:sparkles: feat(scope): what the change does

<the body: why, in plain words>

Co-Authored-By: <Agent> · <Engine> · <Provider> [<Model>]
<Platform>-Session: <the full session or conversation URL, when the platform gives one>
```

Helper	A footer might read
ChatGPT, named by its person	`Co-Authored-By: <its name> · ChatGPT · OpenAI [<model>]`
Codex	`Co-Authored-By: <its name> · Codex · OpenAI [<model>]`
A Harness Cosmos agent	`Co-Authored-By: <its name> · Cosmos · <provider> [<model>]` and `Cosmos-Session: <url>`

The middle dot is `·` (U+00B7); the model goes in square brackets; the session line is its own line. The full spec, including gateways, is `../AGENT-SYNC/README.md`. The subject's Gitmoji is a hint, not a gate (`../GITMOJI.md`); the footer is enforced by the repository's commit hook where one is installed.

A helper that cannot commit (a chat with no write access) drafts the change and the footer; its person, or a fleet helper, commits it with that footer.

Worked FAQ: three questions an outside helper asked

These are the three questions a member's own ChatGPT helper asked before its first change. They are good questions for any helper to ask; the answers are the general ones.

▼ 1 · "Are there unfinished changes on the rehearsal branch I should know about?"

Look before you start:

- **Open pull requests:** `https://github.com/<org>/<repo>/pulls`. Anything open into `preview` is someone's work in progress.
- **`preview` ahead of `main`:** `https://github.com/<org>/<repo>/compare/main...preview`. Commits listed there have been rehearsed and are waiting for a Promote.
- Neither list is your work to finish. If something there touches the same pages, say so in your pull request, or ask.

▼ 2 · "Where do I see the rehearsal (preview) site?"

A site with lanes publishes two websites (SOP-OPS-001, *Two things called preview*):

- **Rehearsal:** `https://<org>.github.io/<site>-publish-preview/`, with a "Rehearsal" ribbon. It rebuilds a few minutes after anything is merged into `preview`.
- **Live:** the site's own domain, rebuilt when a Promote is merged into `main`.

The site's admin panel (the key icon at the foot of each page) shows both, and its prompts are written for helpers. A repository without lanes has no rehearsal website: its rehearsal is the `preview` branch on GitHub.

▼ 3 · "How should I make changes: directly, or by pull request?"

By pull request, into `preview`. A helper from outside the fleet never commits to `main` and never pushes to `preview` directly: it opens a pull request into `preview` from its own short branch (step 3 above). A person reviews and merges it; a later Promote carries it to `main`. That way every change is seen by a person twice before visitors see it.

When something goes wrong

It happens	Do this
a push is refused as "not fast-forward"	`git pull --rebase --autostash`, then push again; never force
the commit hook refuses the message	add the two trailer lines exactly; check the middle dots
you are asked for a password, a token or a recovery code	refuse; access is your person's to give, through their own settings (SOP-IT-002)
a page would put something private in public	stop and say so in the pull request; `../NAMES-POLICY.md` says what never goes public

Suggest a change

Noticed something? Open an issue or a pull request against `main`, changing this page; a steward reads it and a person with the role merges, with a merge commit, so your name stays on it. An AI helper may do all of that up to the merge, signed as the attribution spec says. Not on

GitHub? Tell any steward you know, or your helper, in your own words.

Related: `JOIN-AN-ORGANIZATION.md` (for the person), `MANY-AI-TOOLS-ONE-TEAM.md`, `ULTRA-RUNS.md`. Added 2026-11-01. Part of the walkthroughs. Icons: Lucide (ISC).